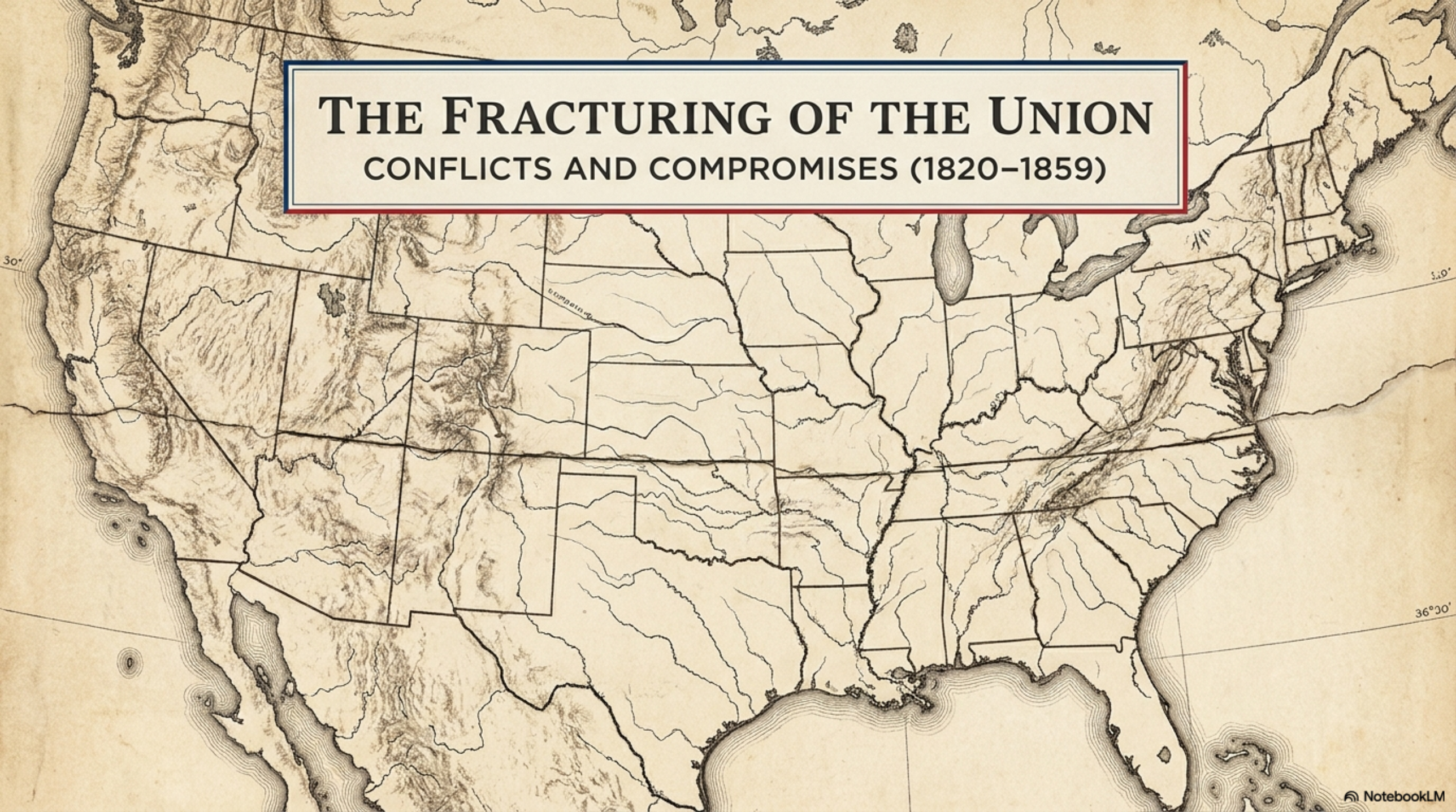

The Fracturing of the Union

Conflicts and Compromises (1820–1859)

The Core Friction Point: Will Slavery Expand Westward?

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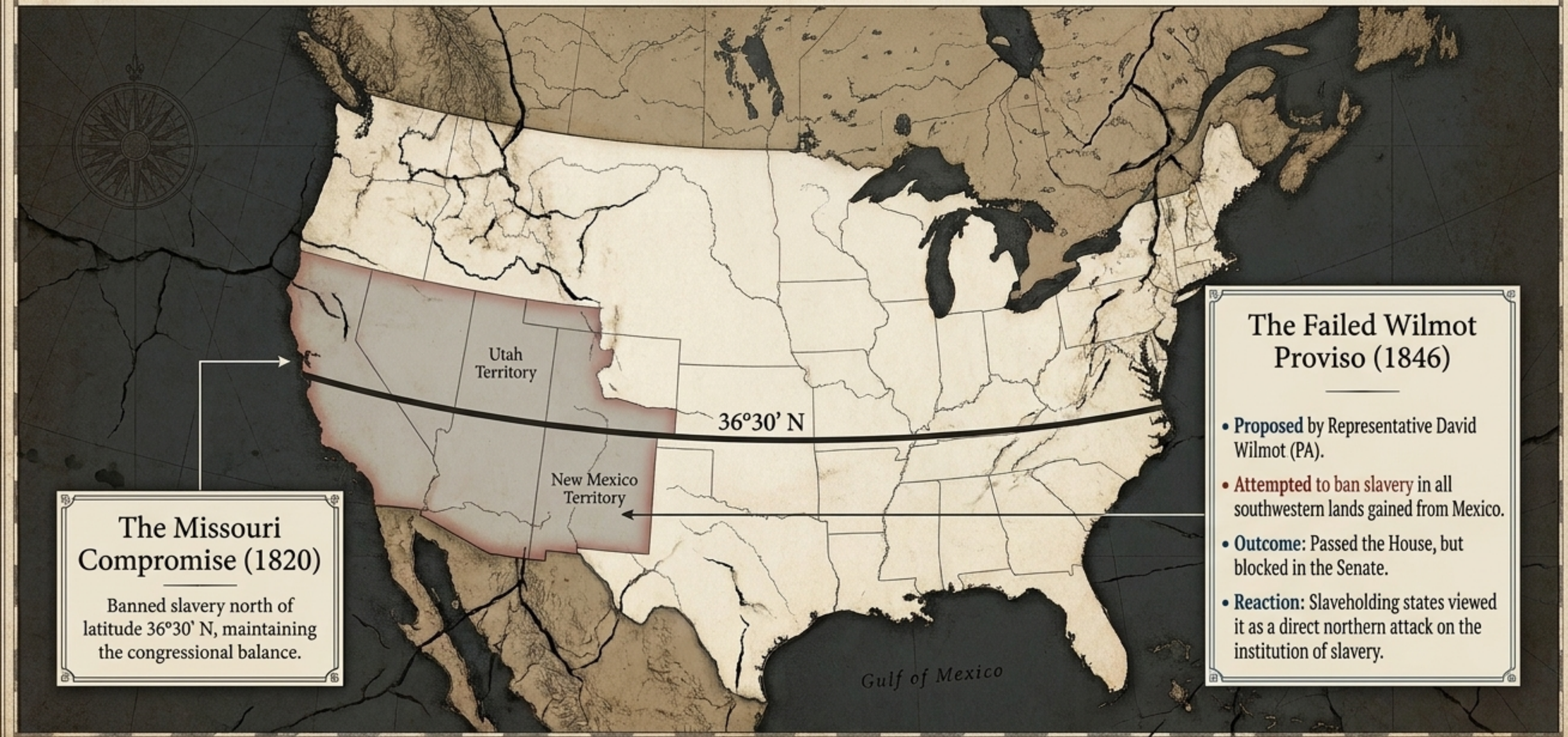
The Fragile Baseline and the First Crack (1820 & 1846)



The Missouri Compromise (1820)

Banned slavery north of latitude 36°30' N, maintaining the congressional balance.

The Failed Wilmot Proviso (1846)

- **Proposed** by Representative David Wilmot (PA).
- **Attempted** to ban slavery in all southwestern lands gained from Mexico.
- **Outcome:** Passed the House, but blocked in the Senate.
- **Reaction:** Slaveholding states viewed it as a direct northern attack on the institution of slavery.

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The Compromise of 1850: A Precarious Balance Sheet

Context: Pushed by Senator Henry Clay and signed by President Millard Fillmore, five bills temporarily halted Southern threats to secede over the admission of California, which threatened to give free states a Senate majority.

Northern Gains	Southern Gains
• California admitted to the Union as a free state. • The slave trade banned within the nation's capital.	• Popular Sovereignty established in the rest of the Mexican Cession to decide the slavery question. • The enactment of a brutal new Fugitive Slave Act.

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The Human Impact: Law vs. Culture (1850–1852)

The Fugitive Slave Act (1850)

- Government officials permitted to arrest anyone accused of trying to escape slavery.
- Suspects denied the right to prove false accusation in a trial.
- Deprivation of freedom required only the word of one white person.
- Northerners legally required to assist authorities in capturing escapees.

Uncle Tom's Cabin (1852)

- Published by northerner Harriet Beecher Stowe.
- Depicted a kind enslaved man abused by a cruel master.
- Impact: Became a northern bestseller, shocking thousands previously unconcerned about slavery.
- Revealed slavery not just as a political conflict, but as a "real human problem."

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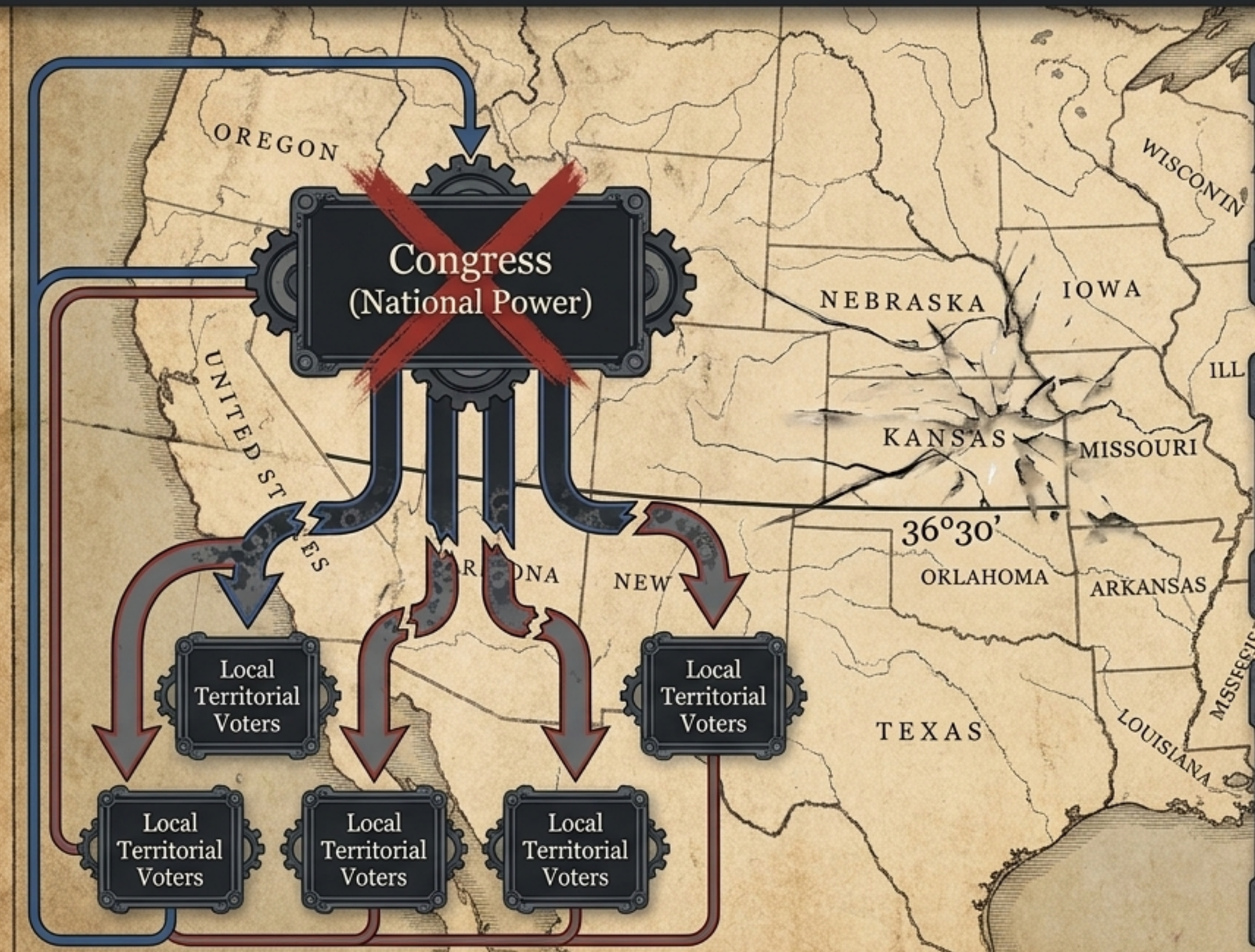
Undoing the Map: The Kansas-Nebraska Act (1854)



The Proposal

Illinois Senator Stephen A. Douglas proposes forming Kansas and Nebraska territories. Both lay north of 36°30’ (closed to slavery).

The Concession

To win Southern votes, Douglas proposes using popular sovereignty to decide the slavery issue in these territories.

The Result

The Act passes both houses in 1854, effectively repealing the Missouri Compromise and reopening the slavery question in the West. Northerners are outraged; Southerners are appeased.

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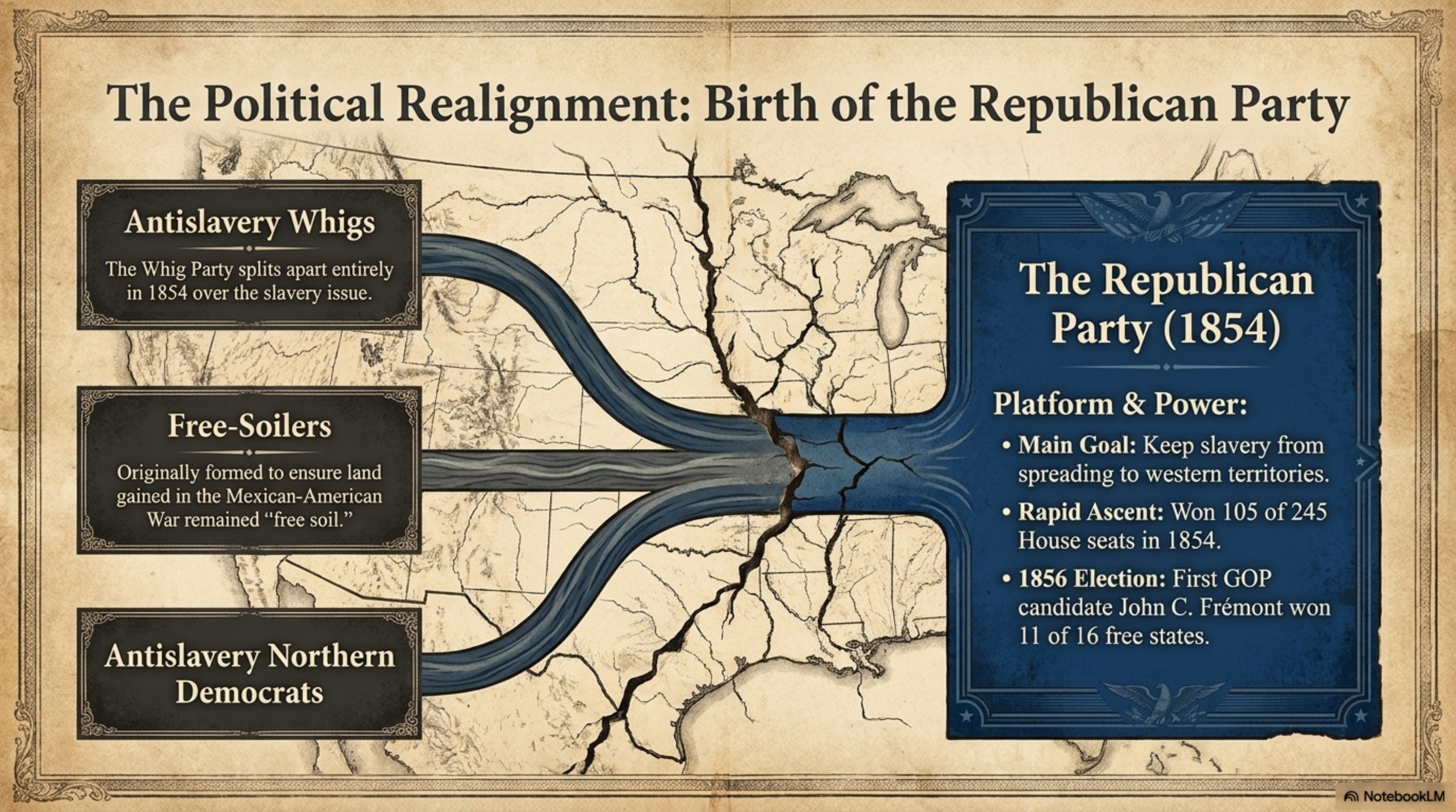
The Political Realignment: Birth of the Republican Party



Antislavery Whigs

The Whig Party splits apart entirely in 1854 over the slavery issue.

Free-Soilers

Originally formed to ensure land gained in the Mexican-American War remained “free soil.”

Antislavery Northern Democrats

The Republican Party (1854)

Platform & Power:

- **Main Goal:** Keep slavery from spreading to western territories.
- **Rapid Ascent:** Won 105 of 245 House seats in 1854.
- **1856 Election:** First GOP candidate John C. Frémont won 11 of 16 free states.

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“Bleeding Kansas” (1855)

Step 1: The Flawed Vote (March 1855)

Kansas holds a popular sovereignty vote. Only 3,000 eligible voters live in Kansas, but 8,000 votes are cast due to thousands of proslavery Missourians voting illegally.

Step 2: Dual Governments

A proslavery government is elected. Antislavery Kansans reject the fraudulent results and establish a second, rival government.

Step 3: Rural Terror

Violence breaks out. Pro- and antislavery factions terrorize the countryside, attacking and killing settlers, earning the territory the name “Bleeding Kansas.”

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Violence in the Senate: The Breakdown of Decorum

The Event

After Massachusetts Senator Charles Sumner delivered a fiery speech attacking a South Carolina senator, the SC senator's nephew brutally and physically assaulted Sumner directly on the Senate floor.

Southern Reaction

Broad approval; many felt Sumner "got what he deserved."

Northern Reaction

Viewed as undeniable, horrific evidence that the institution of slavery was inherently brutal and inhumane.

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The Dred Scott Blow (1857)

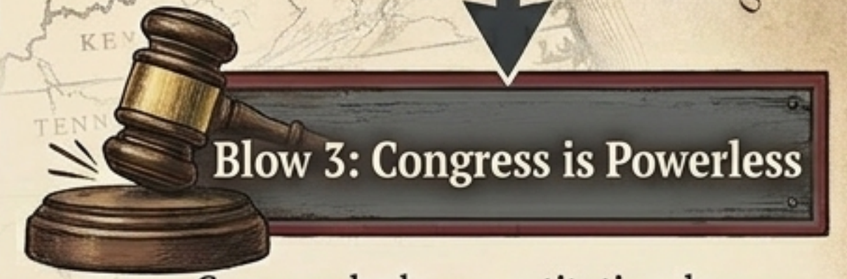
Context: Dred Scott, an enslaved man, sued for freedom because he had lived with his master in states where slavery was illegal.

Blow 1: Not Citizens

Enslaved people were not citizens and therefore had no right to sue in federal court.

Blow 2: Property Everywhere

Living in a free state did not grant freedom; enslaved people were deemed property, and property rights were protected in all states.



Blow 3: Congress is Powerless

Congress had no constitutional power to prohibit slavery in any territory.

The Devastating Conclusion

The Missouri Compromise was declared unconstitutional. Slavery was legally protected in all territories. The North was stunned; the South rejoiced.

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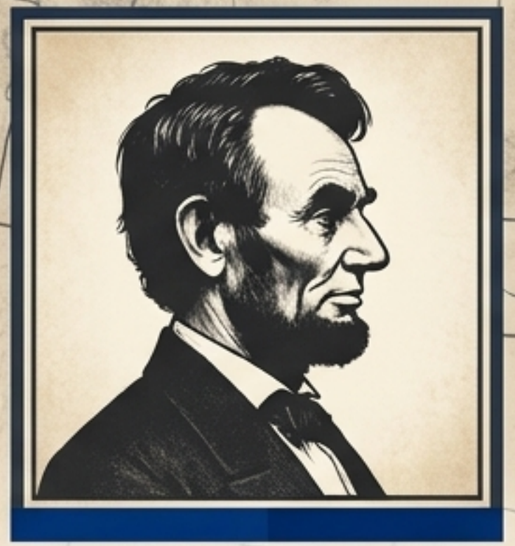
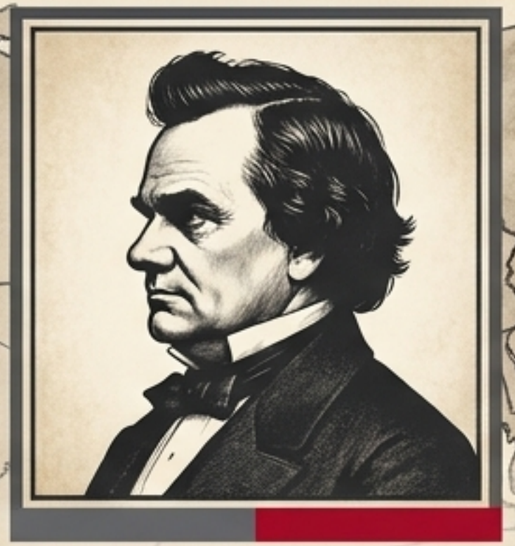
The Ideological Showdown: Lincoln vs. Douglas (1858)



Abraham Lincoln (Republican)

- Former Whig attorney; returned to politics specifically to oppose the Kansas-Nebraska Act.
- Platform: The Union cannot survive "half slave and half free."
- Perception: Widely viewed by Southerners as a radical abolitionist.



Stephen A. Douglas (Democrat)

- Incumbent Illinois Senator and author of the Kansas-Nebraska Act.
- Platform: Defended "Popular Sovereignty" as the only democratic solution for the territories.

The Event

Lincoln challenged Douglas to a series of public debates for the IL Senate seat, drawing massive crowds of thousands and cementing the national divide.

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The Spark of Insurrection: John Brown's Raid (1859)

The Actor

John Brown, a radical abolitionist previously driven out of Kansas for killing proslavery settlers.

The Plan

Attack the U.S. Army arsenal at Harpers Ferry, Virginia, seize the weapons, arm enslaved African Americans, and lead a mass revolt across the South.

The Reality & Fallout

- Brown and his small band were captured and executed.
- Northern Reaction: Celebrated as a hero and a martyr for the abolitionist cause.
- Southern Reaction: Convinced more than ever that the North was actively plotting to destroy their way of life.

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Synthesis Matrix: Two Americas

	Northern Perspective	Southern Perspective
The Fugitive Slave Act (1850)	Outrage over legal corplicity; spurred cultural awakening (Uncle Tom's Cabin).	Viewed as a necessary and rightful protection of their "property."
The Dred Scott Decision (1857)	Stunned disbelief; viewed as a total loss of legislative power to contain slavery.	Jubilation; absolute legal validation of slavery's expansion everywhere.
John Brown's Raid (1859)	Mourned as the martyrdom of a hero fighting an unjust system.	Existential terror; viewed as proof the North intended to destroy the South.

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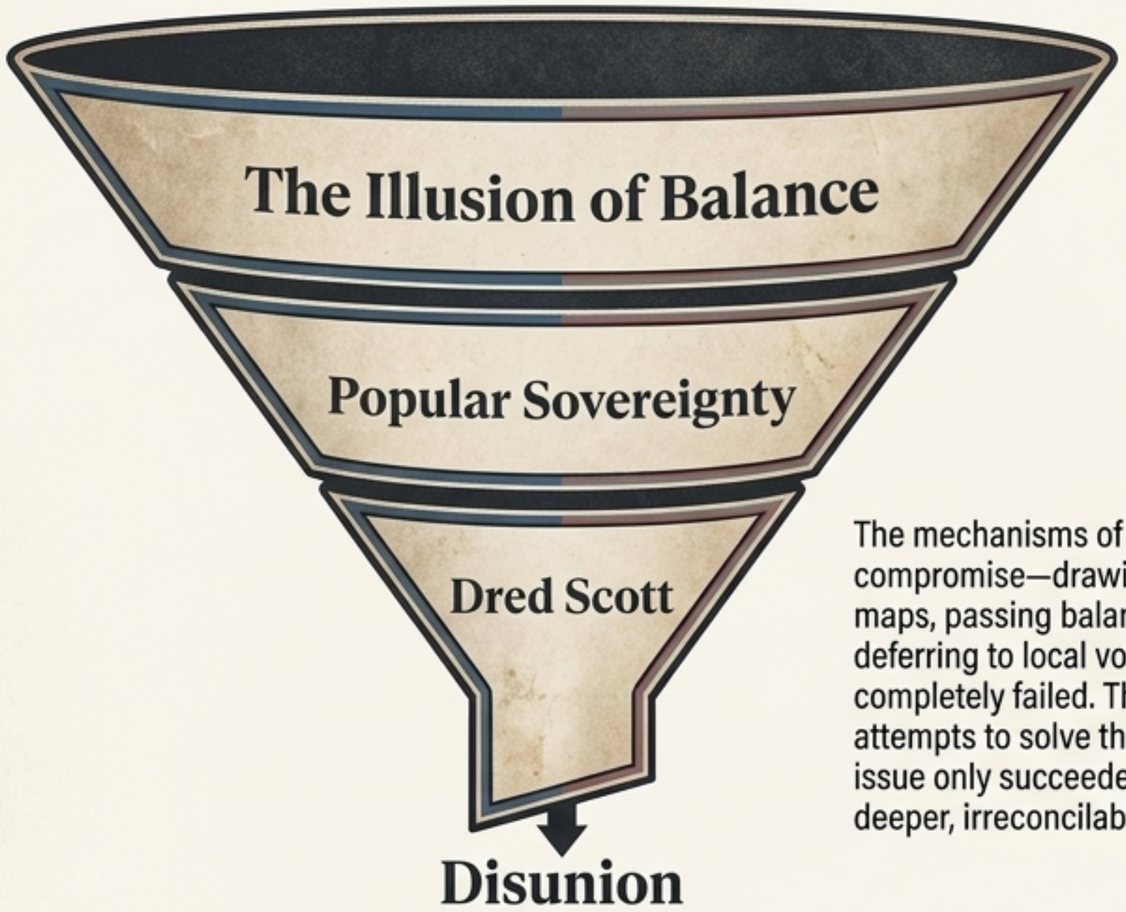
The End of Compromise



The mechanisms of compromise—drawing lines on maps, passing balancing bills, and deferring to local voters—had completely failed. The legislative attempts to solve the slavery issue only succeeded in creating deeper, irreconcilable divisions.

"The country could not survive half slave and half free." — Abraham Lincoln, 1858

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